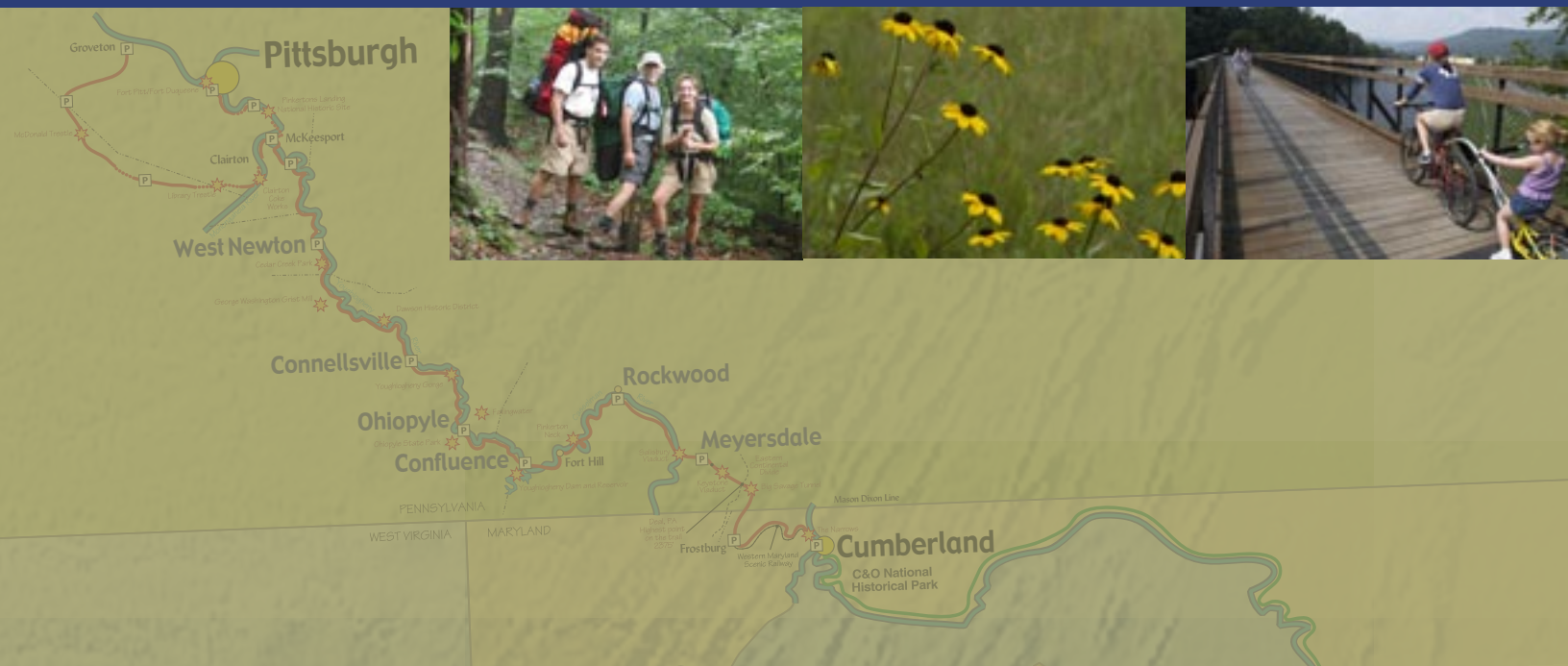




Trail Town Program

An economic development initiative along the Great Allegheny Passage





Imagine a glorious summer weekend in the Laurel Highlands of Pennsylvania. People are out in droves discovering the beauty of the region, a place whose legacy is steeped in industry and is now regenerating itself through tourism and recreation. Take the Great Allegheny Passage, for example. This railroad corridor-turned-trail has become a main thoroughfare for cyclists. They follow winding rivers, marvel at mountain peaks and valleys, and discover the heritage of towns along the way. These cyclists frequent local campgrounds, restaurants, bike shops, grocery stores, pubs, small town shops, laundromats, and delis. They also seek out a touch of luxury in the form of B&B's, massage therapy, art galleries, mountaintop wineries, and the world-famous Frank Lloyd Wright houses.

As early as March and April, riding enthusiasts hop on the trail and ride its 132 mile duration, some even making the longer 335 mile trek from Washington, D.C. By May and June the impact is clearly visible. Spend an afternoon on the trail and you'll find every kind of trail user: long-distance cyclists; visitors who do "some biking, some driving" as they tool around the Laurel Highlands; Pittsburghers out for a day ride; and local families enjoying a well-earned ice cream stop.

At last count, the Passage hosted nearly 350,000 visits and generated over \$7 million in direct spending. To put this in other words, on a typical summer Saturday you might find hundreds of people at any given trailhead. A hundred visitors in a single day adds up to great opportunity in a community like Rockwood, Somerset County (population 947). Over the course of a season, that's spending to the tune of over \$300,000. And that's just Rockwood. Other communities along the trail have experienced similar benefit. It's no wonder that over 30 Somerset County businesses attribute their opening to the Passage.



Trail Town Program Vision

The Trail Town Program envisions a corridor of revitalized trailside communities along the Great Allegheny Passage that reap the economic benefits of trail-based tourism and recreation as part of a larger, coordinated approach to regional economic development. The long-term economic viability of participating communities is to be achieved through concentrated business development efforts that capitalize on the trail user market.

Incredible potential inspires Trail Town Program

Recognizing the incredible economic potential of the Great Allegheny Passage, the Allegheny Trail Alliance secured a planning grant from Pennsylvania's Department of Conservation and Natural Resources and convened a steering committee in 2002. The committee met over the next couple of years and further developed the Trail Town concept. ATA and The Progress Fund, which now operates the Trail Town Program, worked to secure funding.

As a non-profit lender to businesses in the travel and tourism industry, The Progress Fund has always supported trailside businesses. It helped to expand and open businesses like The Inn at Lenora's, Wilderness Voyageurs Outfitters, and Hazelbaker Recreational Services. The Progress Fund's motto may be "growing the tourism industry one business at a time," but it recognized that its traditional role as a lender could only bring about so much change. It saw the Trail Town Program as an opportunity to create jobs and grow business "one community at a time." The Trail Town Program goals are simple:

- 1) Retain existing businesses
- 2) Expand and increase revenues of existing businesses
- 3) Recruit sustainable new businesses
- 4) Adopt the Trail Town vision and integrate its concept of a visitor friendly environment in community planning

About the towns...

Six Laurel Highlands communities are participating in the Trail Town Program. Trail Towns along the Great Allegheny Passage (from east to west) include:

Meyersdale – One of the largest of our small towns, the “Maple City” hosts the PA Maple Festival each year and is the closest town to the Maryland state border. Meyersdale is near breathtaking scenery and thrilling trail features like the Big Savage Tunnel and 101-foot-high Salisbury Viaduct.

Rockwood – This charming trailside community has a small town feel but offers trail services in a big way. B&B's, bike shops, and restaurants are all at the trailhead or just in town. Rockwood Opera House and Mill Shoppes is an old mill-turned-multipurpose building in the center of town.

Confluence – The town motto is “Where mountains touch rivers” and you will know why when you visit. Confluence is a great little vacation community with riverside dining and a lovely town square. Events like Pumpkin Fest and Old Home Days are full of small town charm.

Ohiopyle – Once known as Falls City, Ohiopyle has been a tourist destination since the advent of the railroads. Today, Ohiopyle is home to the renowned Ohiopyle State Park and is the most frequented of all of the Trail Towns with 1.5 million visitors annually.

Connellsville – The only city among the Trail Towns, Connellsville's coke factories once fueled the regional economy. The industry was so lucrative that Connellsville is believed to have once boasted more millionaires per per capita than any US city of its size. The result is a city with great river access and elaborate buildings just waiting to be restored.

West Newton – The closest of the towns to Pittsburgh, West Newton is a historic community in the midst of a major facelift. The “Bridge to Tomorrow” that connects the trail to town will soon take trail users to a new town square and into the business community.

Signs of Progress

Trail-related businesses continue to open and expand in each of the Trail Towns and anticipate record numbers given the recent connection to the C&O Canal Towpath to Washington, D.C. Small businesses are a major focus of the Trail Town Program and will benefit from special attention and access to loans. Program staff can connect investors to market information, financial resources, and available properties.



**347,000 annual visits and
\$7.26 million in annual
direct spending**

Source: 2002 Economic
Impact Study



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To learn more, contact us today!

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Project Funding

These partners have invested in the future of communities along the Great Allegheny Passage by financially supporting the Trail Town Program:

- Claude Worthington Benedum Foundation
- Richard King Mellon Foundation
- Anonymous donor
- The Katherine Mabis McKenna Foundation, Inc.
- Community Foundation of Fayette County
- PA Department of Community and Economic Development
- PA Department of Conservation and Natural Resources

MOST DESIRED SERVICES BY TRAIL USERS, according to a trail user intercept survey in Fall 2006:

Restaurants & cafes
Grocery stores
Train service

Bike shops
Gift shops
Bars and taverns

Most preferred lodging services:
B&B's, cabins, and cottages

Recent Connection Offers Opportunities

With the Great Allegheny Passage now connected to the C&O Canal Towpath, trail users can make the 335 mile trek from Washington, D.C. to near Pittsburgh and are eager to do so.

Businesses all along the trail are gearing up to host!

Photos by:
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TrailBook
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